

Names of Large Exotic Animals and the *Urheimat* of Japonic

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Abstract

This article argues that three words designating large tropical animals not endemic for Japan: *kisa* ‘elephant’, *tora* ‘tiger’, and *wani* ‘saltwater crocodile’ were borrowed into Japonic from Austroasiatic or Kradai languages. If so, this becomes another important piece of evidence for locating the *Urheimat* of the Japonic Language family in Southern China and/or Northern South-East Asia driving yet another nail into the coffin of the ‘Altaic’ theory. Since all these words are disyllabic, they also contribute to the reconstruction of the disyllabic words in Austroasiatic and Kradai. This is especially important in the case of Kradai, where in spite of the rather recent fall of the monosyllabic curtain, the idea about the ‘primordial’ nature of the monosyllabic structure is still enjoying considerable support.

Keywords

Japonic reconstruction – Austroasiatic reconstruction – Kradai reconstruction – monosyllabism – polysyllabism

1 Introduction

It is well known that it is not necessary for an animal to be endemic in order for a given language to have a name for it. Thus, for example, Russian has *слон* /slon/ ‘elephant’ and *верблюд* /verblyud/ ‘camel’, although these animals have never roamed Eastern European savannas or deserts. Two most common ways for acquisition of such names is either borrowing or different kinds of internal

derivations. The Japanese language is no exception to this general rule: all words discussed in this short article fall under the first category, although they look very ‘native’ at the first glance. But it is enough to look at the depictions of elephants and tigers in the works of pre-modern Japanese art to realize that Japanese until modern times have never seen a live specimen of these animals that have their etymologies discussed below.

2 *Kisa* ‘Elephant’

Unfortunately, the first reliable phonographic attestation of this word is only from the early Heian period, and although it appears in the *man’yōgana* script as 岐佐 *kisa* (WMS 18.16a), we do not know for sure whether it was *kisa* or *kīsa*, because in Western Old Japanese we have only a logographic attestation of this word as 象 ‘elephant’ or 牙 ‘ivory’ in placenames 牙山 *Kisayama* (MYS 6.924), 象之中山 *Kisayama-nə naka yama* (MYS 1.70),¹ and 象之小河 *Kisa-nə wo^h-gapa²* (MYS 3.316, MYS 3.332). However, since *woj* /i/ in the first syllable is extremely rare, the likelihood of having *kisa* rather than *kīsa* is extremely strong. The next attestation is from the end of the eleventh century. It gives quite conflicting information on the accent and in one case on segmental phonology as well: *kisa* LH, *kiⁿza* LH, and *kisa* HL ‘elephant’ (RMS 178).³ As far as I can tell, *kisa* ‘elephant’ after that completely disappears from the language. There are no Ryūkyūan or dialect attestations, either, although in the case of Ryūkyūan it might be purely accidental, as the word might have been simply lost.

I believe that *woj kisa* ‘elephant’ was borrowed from Austroasiatic during the period when speakers of Proto-Japonic still lived in South China. The more exact source is Palaungic:

Reconstructions:

PP *(k)caŋ ‘elephant’ (Sidwell 2010: reconstructed as #457) > PWL *ksaŋ ‘id.’ (Diffloth 1980: reconstructed as # N7 9-4) > PW *ksaŋ ‘id.’ (Diffloth 1980: reconstructed as # N79-1).

1 Referring to the same mountain as *Kisayama*. For the detailed commentary on the location see Vovin (2017: 159–160). The etymological commentary found there is now superseded by the commentary in the present article.

2 It is a river flowing in *Kisa* valley under *Kisa* mountain.

3 Cited according to Mochizuki Ikuko’s edition (1974). Note that in PJ all word-final consonants are lost except *-m that left a reflex of falling (F) pitch accent in 2.5 (LF) accent class of nouns and *-y that can be recovered through the internal reconstruction.

Actual attestations in Palaungic:

Wa *hsang* ‘elephant’ (Antisdel 1911 cited in Diffloth 1980: 47), (Drage 1907 cited in Diffloth 1980: 170), Tai Loi *k’sang* ‘id.’ (Scott 1900 cited in Diffloth 1980: 260), Khalo *ka sāŋ* (Flatz 1970 cited in Diffloth 1980: 54), Kem Dègne *kesaŋ* ‘id.’ (Lefèvre-Pontalis 1892 cited in Diffloth 1980: 28), Samtau *kəsáŋ* ‘id.’ (Harris and Gainey 1976 *apud* Diffloth 1980: 281), Danaw *kətsaŋ*⁴ ‘id.’ (Luce 1964 cited as entry D 102).

The other Austroasiatic attestations outside Palaungic are sporadic, and it is not clear whether they are cognates to Palaungic *ksaŋ or not (Pittayaporn, January 2021, p.c.). They are provided below organized by a name of an Austroasiatic branch:

Katuic

Proto-Katuic *ʔaciaŋ ‘elephant’ (Sidwell 2005: reconstruction #813).

Khmuic

Cuang Khmu *sca:ŋ* ‘elephant’ (Suwilai, Premssirat 2002: cited as #485).

Vietic

pv *ʔa-ja:ŋ ‘elephant’ (Ferlus 2007:⁴ reconstruction #1130) > Malieng *kaŋaŋ*¹ ‘elephant tusk’ (Ferlus 2007: cited as #109-1).

The Austroasiatic origin of woJ *kisa* ‘elephant’ is, therefore, quite likely, although a limited distribution in both Japonic and Austroasiatic remains a fly in the ointment. Note that the variation of vowels in the first syllable: $\emptyset \sim a \sim e \sim \partial \sim ^\circ$ points to the original *e, which is perfectly suitable, since woJ *i* can result from the raising of PJ *e. Thus, PAA and PJ forms simply confirm each other.

3 Old Japanese *Tora* ‘Tiger’

The single EOJ attestation in MYS 16.3885 is in the logographic script, so essentially we have to rely on woJ *tora*. Cf also MJ *tora* HH ‘id.’ The fact that we have *tora*, and not *təra* is very important, because it invalidates a frequent folk etymology connecting it to Japanese *tor-* ‘to take’, see, e.g. Yoshida (2001: 172).

4 This notation for an unpublished paper is taken from the on-line Mon-Khmer Comparative Dictionary (<http://sealang.net/monkhmer/dictionary/>).

However, as Bentley convincingly demonstrated, there were two verbs in WOJ: *tər-* ‘to grab’, ‘to catch’, ‘to take’, ‘to capture’ and *tor-* ‘to hold’, ‘to support’ (1999). Even leaving aside a functional problem: I know of no cases when *-a forms a verbal noun with a function of a *nomen agentis*, as it is an obsolete suffix for deriving denominal resultative objects, like, e. g. *tuk-a* ‘mound’ < *tuk-* ‘to build’. Moreover, it is difficult to imagine a tiger described as a ‘supporter’ or a ‘beholder’. Ryūkyūan attestations are *tora* ~ *tura*: 도라 *twora* in Middle Korean transcription (HCK 8),⁵ 它喇 *tuola* (LGYI, YYZH), 土拉 *tula* (ZSZX), とら *tora* (OS 11.596). Since we have /o/ in 15th–first half of the 16th century, but /u/ in the second part of the 16th century and early eighteenth century, it is very likely that in Proto-Ryūkyūan we had **tora*. PR **tora* is attested in the most of Ryūkyūan dialects from the North to the South, e.g. Yuwan, Izena, Benoki, Kijōka, Arumi, Toguchi, Sesoko, Maejima, Tomigusushi, Kumejima, Higashi Nakasone, Yonaha, Tonosiro *tura* ‘tiger’, Hateruma *tura* ‘tiger’ (Uchima & Arakaki 2000: 425), Nakijin *turaa* LHH ‘id.’ (Nakasone 1983: 317), Iejima *tura* ‘id.’ (Oshio 1999: 253), and Hirara, Nagahama (Irabu), Nakachi (Irabu) and Tarama *turaa* ‘id.’⁶ Consequently PR **tora* ‘tiger’ looks like a retention of Proto-Japonic, rather than an early loan from mainland Japanese. This conclusion is further supported by the fact that a correspondence of North Ryūkyūan *u* to South Ryūkyūan *u* indicates PR **o* (Thorpe 1983: 65–66), providing a second independent piece of evidence in addition to WOJ *tora* for the reconstruction of PJ **tora* ‘tiger’. There is no dearth of attestations of PAA **kla*? ‘tiger’, with reflexes attested in the most of Austroasiatic branches:

Aslian

Central Sakai *kla* ‘black and white tiger’ (Shorto 2006: 197–7).

Bahnaric

Proto-Bahnaric **kla*₁ (Sidwell 2011a: reconstructed as #400) > Proto-North Bahnaric (Sidwell 2011a: reconstructed as #pNB-400⁷), Proto-Central Bahnaric (Sidwell 2011a: reconstructed as #pCB-400), Proto-South Bahnaric **kla*: (Sidwell 2000: reconstructed as #12), Proto-West Bahnaric **kli*: (Sidwell 2003: reconstructed as #1003).

Actual attestations: Kontum Bahnar *klaa* (Banker, John et al. 1979: cited in 2028-1), Stieng *kla* (Shorto 2006: cited in 197-4), Bahnar, Bulu Stieng *kla*:

5 I used a facsimile of the xylograph in Tōjō (1969).

6 Hirara, Nagahama (Irabu), Nakachi (Irabu) and Tarama additions were provided by Aleksandra Jarosz (January 8, 2021, p.c.).

7 Notation of pages or entries is based on Sidwell (2011b).

(Haupers & Haupers 1991: C), (Sidwell 2000: 40), (Shorto 2006: cited in 197-5), Halang *kli.ə* (Cooper and Cooper 1976: cited in 1703), Sapuan *kliə ~ kli:* (Jacq 2002: C), Jru' Laven, Laven, Nyaheun, Sapuan, Laveh Brao *kliə*, Jru' Laven *kliə*: (Ferlus 1969: cited in 108-2), (Huffman 1971: cited in 6103-801-11), (Sidwell 2003 ~ 4824, 4826), Krueng Brao, Laveh Brao, Cheng, Sapuan, Sork *kli* (Ferlus 1969: C), (Kelley 2001: C), (Jacq 2002: cited in 776), (Sidwell 2003 ~ 4833, 4835, 4836), Eastern Mnong, Rölöm Mnong *tla:*, Oi *tlia* (Blood 1976: C), (Sidwell 2000: 39), (Sidwell 2003: 4832), (Blood 2005: C), Cua *ʔo: kla:* (Maier 1981: cited in 400) 'tiger'.

Katuic

Proto-Katuic **kalaa* (Sidwell 2005: reconstructed as #17) 'tiger'.

Actual attestations: Ir *kalaʔ* (Chinda 1978: C), (Sidwell 2005: 17-4), Bru, Kui *klaa* (Huffman 1971: cited in 6103-801-6), (Theraphan and See 1980: cited in 1216), (Sidwell 2005: 17-2), Pacoh *ku.la:* (Watson, Watson, and Cubuat 1979: cited in 6103-801-6), Taleuang Katang, Pacoh *kulaa* (Miller 1988: cited in 1216), (Sidwell 2005: 17-3), TS Bru *kula:* (Theraphan and See 1980: cited in 1216), Bru, Souei *kəlaa* (Ferlus 1974a: C), (Sidwell 2005: 17-1) 'tiger'.

Khasic

Proto-Khasic **kʰla* 'tiger' (Sidwell 2012: reconstructed as #210).

Actual attestations: Khasi, Nangstoin Lyngngam *khla* (Shorto 2006: cited in 197-6), (Nagaraja 1996: cited in 210), Rongrim Lyngngam, Jowai Pnar, Rymbai Pnar *kʰla* (Daladier 2009: cited in 210), (Bareh 2010: cited in 210-1, 2), Khasi *kʰla:*, Khasi *'la* (Singh 1906: cited in 1841, 1842), Amwi War *kʰli* (Weidert 1975: cited in 210) 'tiger'.

*Khmeric*⁸

Actual attestations: Khmer *klaa* (Huffman 1971: cited in 6103-801-1), Khmer, Surin Khmer *kʰla:* (Shorto 2006: cited in 197-3), (Chantrupanth 1978: cited in 742) 'tiger', Khmer *khaal* (Headley 1997: cited in 1567), Surin Khmer *kha:l* (Chantrupanth 1978: cited in 2012) 'year of the tiger'.⁹

Monic

Proto-Monic **klaaʔ* (Diffloth 1984: reconstructed as #N3) 'tiger'.

⁸ No reconstruction is provided in Sidwell (2011b).

⁹ Khmer *khaal* and Surin Khmer *kha:l* 'year of the tiger' are most likely related to other 'tiger' words, but the development of these forms seems to be irregular.

Actual attestations: Old Mon *klaʔ, klaʔ, kla, klaʔ* (Shorto 1971: cited in 62.8.1), Middle Mon *kla* (Shorto 1971: cited in 62.8.2), Mon *klaʔ, klaʔ* (Shorto 1962: cited in 2929), (Shorto 2006: cited in 197-2), Northern Nyah Kur *khláaʔ* (Theraphan 1984: cited in 1159, 1–2), (Diffloth 1984: reconstructed as #N3-1), Nam Lao Nyah Kur *khláaʔ*, Rao Mon *khláʔ* (Diffloth 1984: reconstructed as #N3-2) ‘tiger’.

Vietic

Proto-Vietic **kʰa:lʔ > *k-ha:lʔ¹⁰ > kʰa:lʔ* (Ferlus 2007: reconstructed as #570), Proto-Pong **kha:lʔ* ‘tiger’ (Ferlus 2007: reconstructed as #570-4).

Actual attestations: Hanoi Vietnamese *khái* (Ferlus 2007: reconstructed as # 570-11), Rục Chú’t, Sách Chú’t *kuhá:lʔ* (Ferlus 2007: reconstructed as # 570-1, 2), Rục Chú’t *kuhá:l* (Nguyễn, Trần et Ferlus 1998: cited in 590), Thavung *kaha:lʔ* (Ferlus 2007: cited in 570-3), Toum Pong *kha:l* (Ferlus 2007: cited in 570-5), Son La Mu’ong (Ferlus 2007: cited in 570-9), Cuoi Cham Tho *kʰal:lʔ* (Ferlus 2007: cited in 570-7), Liha Pong *kʰa:n* (Ferlus 2007: cited in 570-6), Thanh Hoa Mu’ong *kʰa:nʔ* (Ferlus 2007: cited in 570-10) ‘tiger’.

At the first glance, there is a problem with this etymology, since we have mostly initial velar clusters in Austroasiatic, but **tor-* with a dental **t-* in Japonic. But the clusters dental + /l/ or /r/ are notoriously unstable cross-linguistically. For example, Proto-Tai **tl-* > South-Western and Central Tai **t-*, Northern Tai **l-*, Proto-Tai **tr-* > South-Western and Northern Tai **t-*, Central Tai **h-* or **th-*, Proto-Tai **thl-* > South-Western Tai **h-*, Central Tai **th-*, Northern Tai **š-*, Proto-Tai **thr-* > South-Western Tai **h-*, Central Tai **h-* or **th-*, Northern Tai **hr-* (Li 1977: 118–125). While there are rich systems of labials or velars + /l/ or /r/ clusters in Modern Siamese: *pl-*, *phl-*, *pr-*, *phr-*, *kl-*, *khl-*, *kr-*, *khr-*, there is only one dental + /r/ cluster *tr-* (Smyth 2002: 18), which, as far as I can tell occurs only in loanwords and is never found in the native vocabulary. Consequently, such forms as Bahnaric Eastern Mnong, Rölöm Mnong *tla-*, and Oi *tlia* ‘tiger’ may actually be more archaic than forms with velars. This might be seen as contradicted by 𪛇 **hláʔ* ‘tiger’ (Schuessler 2009: 49),¹¹ an apparent Austroasiatic loan in Chinese. But since we do not know the relative chronology of Austroasiatic loans into Chinese and into Japonic, this objection may be premature, as loans into Japonic may well predate those into Chinese. Along the same vein, the Austroasiatic word might be originally

10 The reconstruction of a prefix or a presyllable **k-* seems to be inspired by disyllabic Vietic forms that are cited below.

11 The signs found on oracle bones and on Zhou period bronze are pictograms, and not the real characters (Zhong & Xu 1987: 105–106, appendix, p. 61).

disyllabic, as witnessed by the majority of the Katuic forms above: Ir *kala?*, Pacoh *ku.la:*, Taleuang Katang, Pacoh *kulaa*, TS Bru *kula:*, Bru, Souei *kəlaa* ‘tiger’. Khmer *khaal*, Surin Khmer *kha:l* ‘year of the tiger’ as well as all Vietic forms: Hanoi Vietnamese *khái*, Rục Chút, Sách Chút *kuhá:l³*, Rục Chút *kuhá:l*, Thavung *kəha:l¹*, Toun Pong *kha:l*, Son La Mu’o’ng, Cuoi Cham Tho *kʰal:l³*, Liha Pong *kʰa:n*, Thanh Hoa Mu’o’ng *kʰa:n³* ‘tiger’, may also present the evidence for the preservation of the first syllable from an original disyllabic word (keeping in mind that Khmer calendrical terms might be irregular developments as mentioned above). Although Proto-Japonic shows evidence for *o in the first syllable, Austroasiatic supports only *a, *u, and *ə there. Although I have no answer to this puzzle, it is necessary to note that from the point of view of the Japonic historical phonology, WOJ *tora ‘tiger’ is an anomalous form, as we would expect the raising of PJ *o > WOJ u in the first syllable disyllabic nouns (Hayata 1998), e.g. PJ *konbo ‘spider’ > WOJ *kumo* ‘id.’ So we would expect WOJ *tura, not *tora, and this is further confirmed by Ryūkyūan data. Possibly we have here a case of a sporadic analogical development.

4 Western Old Japanese *Wani* ‘Saltwater Crocodile; Mythical Sea Monster’

It is quite customary to assign the meaning ‘shark’ to this word, with one of reasons being that “there is no such an animal in Japan” (Omodaka et al. 1967: 823). Such a reasoning does not make any sense:¹² as we have seen elephants and tigers do not live in Japan either, but there are words for them that were discussed above. Interestingly enough, saltwater crocodiles again point to South China and/or South-East Asia.

The obvious difficulty in reconstructing Proto-Japonic form of this word is that WOJ *-ni* can have four sources: *ni, *noy, *nuy, and *nəy. The last one, *nəy, is the least probable, as the combination of *a - *ə is extremely rare, since it contradicts Arisaka’s law about the incompatibility of *a and *ə within the same morpheme. Exceptions do exist, but they are far and between. The combined cases of *nuy and *noy that we can reconstruct by internal reconstruction occupy only a small fraction as compared with *ni. In addition, MO form わいさば *waisaba* cited below may offer evidence for a palatalization *ni > *nʲi > *yi > i, so it seems more or less reliable to reconstruct PJ *wani here. Unfortunately, as far as I can tell, there is no evidence from the internal reconstruction that can either support or to refute this claim, which is, therefore,

¹² See the critique of the ‘shark’ explanation by Matsumoto (1958: 115).

based exclusively on statistical grounds. There are no Eastern Old Japanese or Old Okinawan attestations as far as I am aware.¹³ However, there are MO attestations わに, わいさば, わんさ, and ベーさ ‘shark’ (Hokama et al. 1995: 738). MO さば *saba* here is likely to be an Okinawan word for ‘shark’, cf. MdO *saba* ‘shark’ (Kokuritsu kokugo kenkyūjo 1963: 452). Thus, in all likelihood we are dealing in the case of MO わいさば *waisaba* with a compound *wai-saba* < *wani + *sa^mba ‘saltwater crocodile’ + ‘shark’. Although the sound change -n- > -Ø- in *wani* > *wai* is irregular, it appears to be significant, since it has to involve an intermediate change -n- > -ɲ-, and, therefore -n- > -ɲ- > -Ø- is a result of the palatalization of -n- before -i-. Consequently, MO *wai-* confirms that PJ form was *wani, not *wanoy or *wanuy, since *-n- in *wanoy or *wanuy would not palatalize. No less important is MO ベーさ *bēsa* < *waisa, because with the fortition *w- > b- this form cannot possibly be Okinawan. Rather, it looks like a Sakishima form from the Southern Ryūkyūan islands,¹⁴ that for reasons unknown was recorded in the *Nantō kayō* as an Okinawan form. In spite of the lack of attestations of Old Okinawan forms, the presence of Southern Ryūkyūan ベーさ *bēsa* confirms beyond any reasonable doubt that WOJ *wani* ‘saltwater crocodile’ can be reconstructed on the Proto-Japonic level.

I think that WOJ *wani* ‘saltwater crocodile’, ‘mythical sea monster’ was borrowed from PT *ɲiək or *ɲiik ‘id.’¹⁵ This word appears to be limited to Tai, and is not attested in other branches of the Kradai language family: Kam-Sui, Kra, and Hlai, but this might be due to the fact that our knowledge of their vocabulary, especially of the Kra branch is very limited.

PT *ɲiək or *ɲiik is believed to be a loan from Old Chinese *ɲâk¹⁶ (鱷) ‘aquatic reptile’, ‘saltwater crocodile’, see Pittayaporn (2009–2010: 16), who believes that PT word is a loan from Chinese *ɲâk (鱷) ‘aquatic reptile’, ‘saltwater crocodile’, which he glosses as ‘crocodile’, ‘alligator’. But there are numerous problems here on the Chinese side. First, *ɲâk (鱷) ‘saltwater crocodile’ should be kept distinct from *dâi, *dân (鼃) ‘freshwater alligator’ (Schuessler 2007:

13 There are Middle Ryūkyūan attestations of わに *wani* in the NTK 76b.58, 130a.10, but the total absence of the word in Old Ryūkyūan and other Ryūkyūan languages strongly suggest that this might be a loan from mainland Japanese.

14 I would like to thank Aleksandra Jarosz for drawing my attention to this fact concerning *bēsa* < *waisa.

15 As far as I am aware, the etymology connecting PT *ɲiik or *ɲiək and PJ *wani was suggested for the first time by Carr (1990: 134), practically without any discussion, but with citation of Benedict’s Indonesian *maɲiwak ‘shark’ < *ma + nasal + *iwak ‘fish’ (1975: 376), which is, of course, totally teleological. Cf. POC *pakiwak ‘shark’ (Blust 2013: 665), PAN *qisu, Blust’s PAN *qisu ‘id.’ (Wolff 2010: 965).

16 I used Schuessler’s reconstruction (2007: 223). Baxter and Sagart 2014 do not reconstruct this word for Old Chinese.

223, 505). Not only crocodiles and alligators are very different animals,¹⁷ the habitat here ('saltwater' vs. 'freshwater') differs as well. Second, Carr's etymology of the word that compares it with OC *ŋâk (𪛗) 'to beat the drum' or with OC *ŋâk (𪛗, 鄂, 愕) 'to fear' (1990: 132ff) is very dubious semantically: one can fear bears, wolves, cobras, etc. as well. As for an alligator or a crocodile skin on a drum, the connection also seems to be a little bit far, as one does not use a whole crocodile or an alligator for a drum cover, but just its skin. Finally, it is the most important that OC *ŋâk (𪛗) 'aquatic reptile', 'saltwater crocodile' is attested for the first time in the *Shuowen* dictionary that was compiled in 100 AD.¹⁸ The fact that this word does not appear in the Shang period oracle bones and the Zhou period bronze inscriptions, the *Shijing* (詩經), and the rich and varied corpus of texts from the Warring States (Zhanguo, 戰國) period is puzzling and cries for the explanation. I think that the same logic as in the case of the directionality of the loan for 'elephant' in Chinese and Tai should be applicable here (Boodberg 1937: 363), (Schuessler 2007: 534–535). Namely, it would be very weird if the word for a 'saltwater crocodile' from the middle of Huang-he (黃河) river basin that lies quite far away from both tropics and the sea would be borrowed by Tai languages in Southern China. Thus, it is considerably more likely that LHC *ŋak (𪛗) would be a loanword from Tai. It is necessary to note that the next attestation after *Shuowen* one is in a poem by Han Yu (韓愈, 768–December 25, 824 AD), which was composed while he was a governor of *Chaozhou* (潮州) in the Eastern Guangdong, which is roughly in the same area.

It is unfortunate that unlike the previous two cases of 'elephant' and 'tiger' there is no evidence for the first syllable in the donor language. Attestations: PT *ŋiək 'saltwater crocodile', 'mythical sea monster' > South-Western Tai: Siamese *ŋiək*³, White Tai *ŋi*⁴, Black Tai *ŋiəʔ*⁵, Shan *ŋik*³ 'crocodile',¹⁹ 'alligator', Nong Khai *ŋiək*⁵, Lue of Chieng Hung, Lue of Muong Yong *ŋiik*⁵, Central Tai: Lei Ping *hiik*⁵, Lungming *ŋiik*⁵, Western Nung *ŋik*⁵, Lungchow *ŋiik*⁴, Ping Siang

17 Crocodiles come from the Crocodylidae family and alligators from the Alligatoridae family. The easiest way to distinguish them is by the shape of their snouts. Alligators have a wide, rounded, *u*-shaped snout, while crocodiles have long, pointed, *v*-shaped snouts. The difference in shape means that alligators can exert more strength from their mouths, which is useful in cracking open hard-shelled vertebrates, like turtles. Crocodiles are considerably more aggressive than alligators, and crocodiles can exceed alligators both in length and weight. Different subspecies of crocodiles can be found either in saltwater or freshwater environments, while alligators prefer freshwater marshes.

18 Consequently, OC *ŋâk (𪛗) may be a ghost, and we should better deal with LHC *ŋak 'aquatic reptile', 'saltwater crocodile'.

19 I do not know why Hudak simplified 'saltwater crocodile' to just 'crocodile': these are very different creatures that have different names.

*ɲiik*⁵; Northern Tai: Yay *ɲiək*⁵, Saek *ɲuək*⁵, Po-ai *ɲiik*⁶ (Li 1977: 282), (Hudak 2008: 137).²⁰ It is necessary to note that Li Fang-Kuei's reconstruction of *iə in this word may be Siamese-oriented, as all other languages except Nong Khai, Yao and Saek have *ii* or *i* (Hudak 2008: 137, with my correction of Hudak's *ɾ* to *i*). If we reconstruct PT *ɲiik D2L, then it is quite compatible with PJ *-ni in *wani.

5 Conclusion

If Japonic *kisa 'elephant', *tora 'tiger', and *wani 'saltwater crocodile' have indeed Austroasiatic and/or Kradai origin, as I was trying to demonstrate in this article, it could mean only that the *Urheimat* of the Japonic language family was located in Southern China or Northern South-East Asia.²¹ This helps to explain most of the puzzles in the early cultural history of Japan, such as rice as the staple food, houses and temples built on stilts, dwellings that are more suited to the protection from heat rather than cold, worship of the Sun, not of Heaven, etc. These facts should not be construed as a kind of proof on a par with linguistics data, because as Lyle Campbell always said, "languages should speak for themselves". But if the homeland of Japonic were located in Inner Asia, the important cultural traits briefly listed above simply would not make any sense. And Inner Asian homeland would be required for the 'Altaic' origins of Japanese: locating it in Southern China would again would counterintuitive. Thus, we now can come one step closer to the refutation of 'Altaic', or at least of the 'Altaic' origins of Japonic. At the same time, I cannot stress enough that I discuss exclusively the language contacts of Japonic with Austroasiatic and Kradai: under no circumstances should this article is to be construed as an attempt to replace the 'Altaic' hypothesis with another 'exciting' hypothesis concerning the origins of Japonic.

The discovery of the Austroasiatic and Kradai origin of the words discussed in this article has also important consequences for the reconstruction of their respective protolanguages. Namely, monosyllabism and tones do not fall from the sky like manna: both have to come from somewhere, and usually it

20 I kept Li Fang-Kuei's segmental transcription, but kept Thomas Hudak and William Gedney notation of Tai tones. Also, following Li Fang-Kuei's lead, I replaced Hudak's *ɾ* with *i*, because there is no phonological opposition between these two.

21 These ideas were previously proposed in Vovin (2010: 115–118), albeit on the basis of different etymologies.

is from earlier disyllabic or polysyllabic structures. The existence of disyllabic Japonic words of Austroasiatic and Kradai provenance demonstrates quite well that once upon a time at least some roots in these languages had disyllabic structure. This is especially important in the case of Kradai, where in spite of the rather recent fall of the monosyllabic curtain, the idea about the ‘primordial’ nature of the monosyllabic structure is still enjoying considerable support.

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Abbreviations

D	Proto-Tai tone D
EOJ	Eastern Old Japanese
F	falling pitch accent in Japanese
H	high pitch accent in Japanese
L	low pitch accent in Japanese, long vowel in Proto-Tai
LHC	Later Han Chinese
MdO	Modern Okinawan
MO	Middle Okinawan
OC	Old Chinese
OJ	Old Japanese (both Western and Eastern)
OO	Old Okinawan
PAA	Proto-Austroasiatic
PAN	Proto-Austronesian
PJ	Proto-Japonic
PKD	Proto-Kradai
POC	Proto-Oceanic
PP	Proto-Palaungic
PR	Proto-Ryūkyūan

PT	Proto-Tai
PV	Proto-Vietic
PW	Proto-Waic
PWL	Proto-Wa-Lawa
WOJ	Western Old Japanese

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Chinese

LGYI	琉球館譯語, <i>Liuqiu gwan yi yu</i> , second half of the 15th c. AD
Shuowen	說文解字, <i>Shuowen jiezi</i> , 100 AD
YYZH	音韻字海, <i>Yinyun zihai</i> , second half (?) of the 16th c. AD
ZSZX	中山傳信錄, <i>Zhongshan zhuan xinlu</i> , 1721 AD

Japanese and Ryūkyūan

MYS	萬葉集, <i>Man'yōshū</i> , between 759 and 785 AD
NTK	南島歌謡, <i>Nantō kayō</i> , 1697–1713 AD
OS	おもろさうし, <i>Omoro sōshi</i> , 1531–1623 AD
WMS	倭名類聚抄, <i>Wamyō Ruijūshō</i> , 931–938 AD

Korean

HCK	海東諸国紀附録語音翻訳, <i>Haytong ceykwukki eum penyek</i> 1501 AD
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